governorship in December 2008 was that I had handled a very turbulent period with intelligence, professional integrity and exemplary calm. Even more gratifying was the one-year evaluation of my governorship in the media in September 2009 where the broad consensus was that the Reserve Bank under my ‘mature and reassuring’ leadership was bold, swift and imaginative in its response to the crisis and that, in an uncertain time, I brought clarity and candour to the central bank.

What was most comforting to me was that some of the very same commentators who had earlier criticized me for surrendering to Delhi’s instructions had now written that I meant business, didn’t bend under pressure and steered the Reserve Bank with calm determination and quiet confidence during a time of great tumult. Writing in the *Business Standard* of 1 February 2010, Sanjaya Baru said: ‘[Subbarao’s] leadership at the central bank through the difficult months of 2009 has, without doubt, been exemplary. As he led his four deputy governors into the boardroom last Friday, he exuded the kind of confidence that only being in charge and in control gives.’

Universal endorsement is perhaps too much to expect in a public policy job. Even in the midst of this wide appreciation, some analysts were more grudging and said that even if I may have passed the test as a crisis manager, that success didn’t say anything about my competence in the bread-and-butter business of central banking—fighting inflation—and that the real test for me was yet to begin. As later developments would show, this summing-up was prophetic.

The Governor’s Bungalow

Even as I was completely preoccupied with the crisis, I also had to complete the transition from Delhi to Mumbai.

The Tilak Lane house that I was occupying as finance secretary had to be vacated within three months of leaving the job or else the Central Public Works Department (CPWD) would charge me a penal rent. That itself was no problem as Urmila too had got a transfer to Mumbai as chief vigilance